CITY OF OPA-LOCKA

"The Great City"

CLERK'S ACTION SUMMARY MINUTES
SPECIAL COMMISSION MEETING
Wednesday, February 27, 2019
6:00 P.M.
Sherbondy Village Auditorium
215 Perviz Avenue
Opa-locka, FL 33054

1. CALL TO ORDER:

Mayor Matthew Pigatt called the meeting to order at 6:00 p.m. on Wednesday, February 27, 2019 in the Auditorium at Sherbondy Village, 215 President Barack Obama (Perviz) Avenue, Opa-locka, Florida.

2. ROLL CALL:

The following members of the City Commission were present: Mayor Matthew Pigatt, Vice Mayor Chris Davis, Commissioner Joseph L. Kelley, Commissioner Alvin Burke, and Commissioner Sherelean Bass. Also in attendance were: Acting City Manager Newall Daughtrey, City Attorney Vincent Brown, and City Clerk Joanna Flores.

3. INVOCATION:

The invocation was delivered by Commissioner Joseph L. Kelley.

4. PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE:

The Pledge of Allegiance was recited in unison.

5. PUBLIC INPUT:
Agenda Items Only

Dorothy Johnson, 13724 NW 22nd Place, Opa-locka, FL, asked if the budget amendment in question will include the eight (8) officers needed at the police department and where will the funds come from?

Mayor Pigatt informed Ms. Johnson that her concern will be addressed during the presentation portion of the meeting.

6. PUBLIC SAFETY PRESENTATION BY CITY MANAGER:

Acting City Manager Daughtrey said the increased crimes and killings appear to come from the people north of the City (Miami Gardens). He asked if the City was being aggressive enough in providing deterrents to prevent violence or does it need to look at other avenues to discourage criminal activity in the neighborhood. The old adage is to train up a child in the way they should go and when this is not done, it becomes a problem for everyone else. It behooves law enforcement to be on high alert to try and prevent these events from happening. The police had

just patrol the area from the last occurrence when the shooting took place and was back on the scene within two (2) minutes. The community also needs to do their part in being observant in what goes on around them. The unspoken rule of "Snitches get Stitches" needs to stop. He asked Chief of Police James Dobson to come before the commission and provide a report on what has been going on recently in the City.

Chief of Police James Dobson said he presented the commission with documents regarding the recent major incidents and recommendations went on to speak on current matters involving the department. He said they are currently enforcing all of the City's rules and ordinances and after speaking with the manager it was decided not to be heavy handed, but to be community based instead of being a forceful presence. The department is presently in the process of hiring four (4) officers and also retaining ten (10 reserves to help monitor the City. He welcomed any questions or comments from the commission.

Vice Mayor Davis asked the chief to repeat the information about the monthly Crime Watch.

Chief Dobson said there are three (3) monthly Crime Watch programs in the City and they meet on a Tuesday or Wednesday. The meeting places are 22nd Avenue Apartments, Glorietta Apartments, and Georgia Ayers Apartments.

Commissioner Bass asked why there weren't any in the single family home areas and only in apartments.

Chief Dobson said the home owners that use to facilitate the program did not want to continue having these meetings in their homes and therefore there was no place to hold the meetings. They will reach out again and see if anyone is willing to host the program.

Commissioner Bass asked the chief to try harder because she lives in a single family home and would not mind having the meetings in her area.

Commissioner Kelley asked the manager to address the residents concern about the hiring of the eight (8) officers.

Acting City Manager Daughtrey said he authorized the chief to hire four (4) of the eight officers that were included in the budget. He did not authorize the other four (4) because there are court orders and arbitration that the City has to pay and those have to be satisfied first, out of the police budget. If the commission wants to do an amendment to pay those monies, then he will do so. The bottom is that the City cannot spend one dollar more than the approved budget.

Commissioner Kelley said the bottom line is that there are not enough Police Officers on the road and the citizens demand service and deserve service. He asked what the chief meant when he said the manager told him not to be heavy handed.

Chief Dobson said it has been said that the police department is too rough and racist among other things when complaints are made. If the police are called because someone has been drinking and loitering, they will turn around and say don't arrest them because they are not bothering anyone. This example is why the department changed the approach of handling issues that could be potential problems.

Commissioner Burke said the Police Department is in turmoil and the manager knows it. The chief may be running the department, but the buck stops with the manager and he needs to do what needs to be done to correct what is going on within the Police Department. This is business, it is not about friendship and if some officers come to work and see that there is favoritism going on, they will not put their best foot forward. Something needs to be done immediately.

7. DISCUSSION/QUESTION & ANSWERS:

8. RESOLUTIONS:

a) A RESOLUTION OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA, DIRECTING THE CITY MANAGER TO ALLOCATE FUNDING NECESSARY TO IMPLEMENT THE RECOMMENDATIONS SET FORTH IN EXHIBIT "A" AND ANY OTHER RECOMMENDATION THE CITY DEEMS PRUDENT, AND TO BRING BACK TO THE CITY COMMISSION A BUDGET AMENDMENT FOR CITY COMMISSION APPRPOVAL; PROVIDING FOR INCORPORATION OF RECITALS; PROVIDING FOR AN EFFECTIVE DATE. *Sponsored by Commissioner Kelley*

The above resolution was read by Attorney Brown.

It was moved by Commissioner Kelley, seconded by Commissioner Burke for discussion.

Commissioner Kelley said he brought the item so that something can be put in place for accountability and to address the challenges within the Police Department. There have been too many short comings and the residents need the services. The tax payers pay for the services and that needs to be provided to them.

Vice Mayor Davis asked if the item can be brought back with more detailed information for him to review.

Acting City Manager Daughtrey said, "Yes."

Mayor Pigatt asked what the cost will be for this.

Acting City Manager Daughtrey said the information will be providing when the budget amendment is submitted in March.

Commissioner Burke said this has always been available to the City, so why is this coming up now. Everyone knows this has always been a problem in the City; it has become normal. If you have to work the police officers overtime, then do so because there needs to be officers patrolling the streets.

Mayor Pigatt asked Chief Dobson which of the things in his report to the commission is not being implemented right now.

Chief Dobson said all of these things are being implemented right now. He said a lot of the things that go on in the department on a daily basis is not reported to the commission; it is handled internally.

Mayor Pigatt asked why the department would work the officers overtime when funds were budgeted to hire four (4) officers immediately.

Mayor Pigatt said the recommendations that the chief has brought forth is already being done so therefore the City needs to implement additional measures to combat the violence. He would like to see expert recommendations to come up with ways to deal with the problem.

Commissioner Kelley said this needs to deal with this right now and address what they plan to do about it and it needs to start with the leadership. He is tired of going through this and the next time something happens, he will hold his own press conference and speak on everything that is and isn't going on, including calling out people who aren't doing what they are supposed to do. The citizens want to know what the commission plans to do about what is going on in the City. He said he will defer the item until a later date.

Mayor Pigatt said he understands the passion coming from Commissioner Kelley because his family has personally been affected by gun violence. Actions speak louder than words and there are strategies and ways to address the issues; they need to bring those strategies to the City and address the issues.

This item was deferred by the sponsor.

9. ADJOURNMENT:

There being no further business to come before the Commission, the meeting adjourned at 6:52 p.m.

MAYOR

ATTEST:

CITY CLERK